meetings outlined, the first meeting was little more than a meet and greet, and the second didn't see any serious discussion. There appeared to be no common ground between the two positions. In contrast to previous contacts, there appeared to have been some room to discuss a joint government that would see a number of governorships and ministries going to the UF, but this didn't appear to be enough for the UF. Massoud refused to disarm his militia, and the Taliban refused to offer more than 50 per cent share of the government or, as one participant claimed, even 50 per cent.[46]

Regardless of the 6+2's failure, the final pre-9/11 shift in global positioning on the Afghan question happened in June 2001, as the Taliban undertook a military build-up close to the Tajikistan border. The military maneuver brought Moscow and Washington in a tighter embrace that resulted in joint military measures to contain the Taliban's advance (to the partisans' delight).[47] India was asked to facilitate US and Russian plans for limited military actions against the Taliban. Organised within the 6+2 framework, India's former foreign secretary Chokila Iyer was formally requested to support Russian action in the Second Indo-Russia Joint Working Group (JWG) meeting in Moscow in 2001.[48] Russia's Federal Security Bureau chief Nicolai Patroshev, undertook personal visits to Tehran and New Delhi to lobby for support. According to Indian officials, New Delhi and Tehran were to expedite the mission while the US and Russia, with the help of Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, were to combat from the front. The aim was to push the Taliban lines back to the 1998 position, 50 km away from Mazar-e-Sharif.[49] The probability of military action only increased when the Taliban banned UN representatives from the territory it controlled, and Russia picked up intelligence that the Taliban was aiming to create 'liberated zones' all over Central Asia and Russia.[50] Washington and Moscow's convergence on the Taliban question, by 2001, signified a key shift in global threat perceptions after the end of the Cold War. Such shifting threat perceptions and the rise of anti-terror rhetoric turned the tables for Pakistan. Starting as a legitimate and powerful actor in Afghanistan in the early 1990s, Islamabad came to be seen as a revisionist and destabilising entity. India, for its part, as the next section shows, convinced the US about the rightness of its strategic assessments on the Taliban and Pakistan.